Germany.12 (All editors-in-chief of GDR newspapers had to appear every Wednesday when they were told how the party wished to see the big events and topics of the week covered).

Abroad, Honecker was perceived as pursuing a ‘more open’ course. In a country all too often characterised by strife, dullness and regimentation, the foreign press now warmed to Honecker’s GDR. ‘The people are getting richer and the whole atmosphere is much happier,’ wrote British journalist Stuart Gardner. He saw well and colourfully dressed people (orange, he noted, seemed to be 1971’s colour among the trend-setters). ‘They look well-fed and content’ – and they are keen to talk to an ‘aggressive-imperialist Englishman without having to keep glancing over their shoulders to see who is listening’. Similar praise came from an American reporter, Henry Krisch, who observed that despite the political and ideological differences, ‘the GDR in 1972 reminds me of West Germany in 1957’. Even visitors from other socialist countries were impressed. Soviet cardiologist Vladimir Metelitsa described Berlin shops as offering a ‘wondrous abundance for us, citizens of the great Soviet Union’. During his trip, he discovered consumer venues whose existence he could not have imagined before – such as a specialised clothing store for expectant mothers.13

Throughout this period, geopolitical realities were gradually drawing the GDR out of its splendid isolation. On 1 September 1971, the ambassadors of the four World War Allies signed the ‘Four Power Agreement’ in which the special political status of Berlin was codified, and the Soviet Union finally accepted the incorporation of West Berlin into the Federal Republic. ‘After the four-power agreement came into force the situation became healthier for West Berlin,’ Honecker pronounced. ‘Détente became a precise trend in international relations.’14 Interestingly, the US State Department gave credit to the new General Secretary:

An important obstacle to an agreement was eliminated in May 1971, undoubtedly with Soviet foreknowledge, when Walter Ulbricht, a long-time foe of East-West accommodation in